

Grice was interested in pragmatics – the study of how we use language in real conversations. This is different from that of semantics, which focuses on the literal use of words and their meaning. Now, Grice noticed that sometimes, when we speak, albeit, when we converse, we sometimes mean more than we say – this is what he called *implicature*, and from this he developed the theory of *conversational implicatures*. In order to have a satisfying conversation, we must endorse what Grice termed “the Cooperative Principle”, (158) while adhering to the “conversational maxims” (159) he set forth. Consider the following, simple conversation between two people:

(S1) Where’s Carla?

(S2) She’s either in the library, or she is at home.

For a sentence like (S2) we know that the truth-conditional for ‘or’ is true, iff an utterance of (a) *She’s in the library* is true, or an utterance of (b) *She is at home* is true. Now a counter-argument can be given: (S2) can be expressed without the speaker’s knowledge of (a) or (b) being true. Yet, this seems to imply that (S2) is then just a guess to (S1). Therefore, I will employ Grice’s theory of *conversational implicatures* to defend the specification of the truth conditional ‘or’ in (S2). This will first be done by explicating his “Cooperative Principle”; then I will do the same for his “maxims”; and lastly I will present the counter-argument, and why it fails to be persuasive.

“According to Grice”, Lycan writes, “the conversational norm-in-chief is the *Cooperative Principle*” (158). So then, what is its significance? When two or more people enter into a

conversation, there is usually some pursuit of a goal, which can (hopefully) be obtained by sticking to the nature of the conversation – by providing useful, relevant information, rather than randomly outputted sentences that have no connection to the conversation. If an individual provides information that does not contribute to the overall health of the conversation, then they are not being “cooperative”, and therefore the structure of the conversation tends to weaken. Therefore, we must make our “conversational contribution such as is required” (158), at the moment it is required, “by the accepted purpose or direction of the talk-exchange” (158), which we find ourselves indulging in. This “summarizes a set of corollaries” that Grice calls “conversational maxims” (159), which I will expand upon, next.

Grice’s “maxims” are essentially rules, or guidelines, that we should follow if we intend to engage in conversation appropriately. The first maxim Lycan calls the “Maxim of Strength” (159), which says that we are to make our “contribution to a conversation as informative as is required” (159), and to not contribute information that is not required. This helps to keep the structure of the conversation strong. The second maxim is known as the “Maxim of Truthfulness” (159), which simply states, “do not say what you believe to be false” (159); for this would surely complicate a conversation. Sometimes we make claims and have little to no evidence to support them. According to Grice, when this happens, we are in violation of the “Maxim of Evidence” – we should “not say that for which [we] lack adequate evidence” (159). The “Maxim of Relevance” tells us to “be relevant” (159), meaning, only say things that can be in some way (the easier the better) related to, or connected to the conversation being had; otherwise, and whether it’s intentional or not, we may be pushing back the goal of the conversation, making it harder to achieve than is necessary. The last two maxims state that we should “avoid ambiguity” and “be brief” (159). So, in other words, avoid attaching *possibility* to

statements to avoid confusion, and make said statements as simplistic as possible for the audience to understand.

Now that we have a better understanding of the “Cooperative Principle” along with the “maxims” that it entails, let us return to the above conversation, regarding (S1) and (S2). A question addressing Carla’s whereabouts is first stated, which is then answered with two utterances (as Strawson would call them), connected by a truth-conditional – in this case – ‘or’. From what we know regarding the definition of the truth-conditional ‘or’, we can expect for the statement (S2) to be true iff at least one of its utterances are true. Now the counterargument is this: that the utterances in a statement like (S2) can be true iff at least one of the utterances are true, but also the speaker responsible for stating (S2) does not know if either utterance is true. Now I will show that (S2) does in-fact follow Grice’s guidelines, i.e., it endorses the “Cooperative Principle”.

When (S2) is analyzed, we see that it holds knowledge, in that, the speaker seems to know that Carla is *either in the library*, or that *she is at home*. The speaker provided only information that was required of them. They didn’t state something random; they stated where Carla most likely is, because that is what was asked of them, and not where Carla most likely is not. Maybe the speaker of (S2) knows that Carla is a librarian and when she is not at home she tends to be a homebody; and they may never see her anywhere else, so they can’t necessarily know for her to be anywhere else, but what they do know, is that she spends a lot of time in the library and at home. Admittedly, we must assume that the speaker of (S2) is not expressing something that they “believe to be false”. If they are telling the truth, then they seem to have evidence to support their statement, again maybe it is that Carla is a librarian and also a homebody. So then, they aren’t stating something that lacks evidence, as long as Carla, more

times than not, spends her time in the library or at home. The content of (S2) provides a plausible answer to (S1), while remaining relevant to the conversation – the answer was relevant to Carla’s location – it didn’t address *Carla’s favorite car*, or *where Steve is traveling to next*. Flowing perfectly into the *ambiguity maxim*, we see that (S2) isn’t ambiguous if Carla can usually be found in the library or at home when asked, “Where’s Carla?”. It’s not like the speaker of (S2) saw her once at the dentist, and now thinks it possible for her to be there just as much as in the library or at home; otherwise, *or at the dentist* would have also been uttered. With all of that, it is safe to say that the speaker of (S2) was quite brief in their response to (S1). Therefore it has been shown through the use of Grice’s *conversational implicatures*, that the counterargument posited against (S2) fails regarding the specification of the truth-conditional ‘or’.